

MIST, METTLE AND MAGIC

Those who brave the journey to Menchukha will be rewarded with the sight of a **pristine valley** where time seems to slow down and nature takes centre stage.

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Tucked away in the far reaches of Arunachal Pradesh, Menchukha is a valley where nature and community thrive side by side.

Known for its healing waters — ‘Men’ meaning medicinal, ‘Chu’ meaning water, and ‘Kha’ meaning ice — the landscape is alive with the energy of its river, snow-capped peaks, and pine-covered hills.

Reaching Menchukha is no easy task, with the border village a long drive away (more than 12 hours from the nearest airport).

The journey feels like an expedition in itself — under-construction routes, rain-affected roads, scattered cattle, and a thick veil of mist that sometimes seems to swallow the way ahead.

But those who brave the journey are rewarded with the sight of a pristine valley, untouched in many ways by modernity, where time seems to slow down and nature takes centre stage.

Beyond its breathtaking landscapes, Menchukha is witness to a surprisingly active lifestyle, which offers glimpses into its sporting culture.

Sporting spirit by the Siyom

Life by the Siyom River is active by instinct. Children are seen playing football on flat fields, a beloved sport across the North-East. Even soldiers stationed at high-altitude posts,

11,000ft above sea level, enjoy a game of cricket against the backdrop of the misty Himalayan peaks.

The Siyom, a tributary of the Brahmaputra, is central to many forms of activity other than farming and fishing. While primarily serving the needs of the settlements along its banks, its calm stretches and challenging rapids embrace river-based sports like kayaking and rafting.

Trekking trails cut across the valley too — some leading up to religious spots like Shekhar Bumji, a hilltop shrine dripping with what locals believe to be holy water.

The path to the iconic

‘Menchukha’ mound, where large white letters welcome visitors at the entrance, is a scenic walk that guides one to an insurmountable vantage point.

Upon reaching the sign at the top, the final reward is the view of the entire village and a beautiful sunrise peeking through — a spectacle even Chief Minister Pema Khandu was keen to witness.

Even on a windy, chilly morning, with cloud cover and a slight drizzle, the sprightly 45-year-old CM made the most of the early natural light.

A home for adventure racing

Against this backdrop, it felt natural when Menchukha recently hosted the National Adventure Racing Championship, a demanding team sport combining running, biking, kayaking, and navigation.

Drawing teams from across India and neighbouring countries for the nation’s first high-altitude border adventure race, the sport found a home here. Endurance and exploration were already part of everyday life, and the race only made visible what the locals had practised for generations.

As visitors cycled through narrow paths, trekked forest trails, and paddled down the Siyom’s rapids, the people of Menchukha gathered in support.

Even the state media from Itanagar flocked to the usually quiet town to capture the historic moment.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT